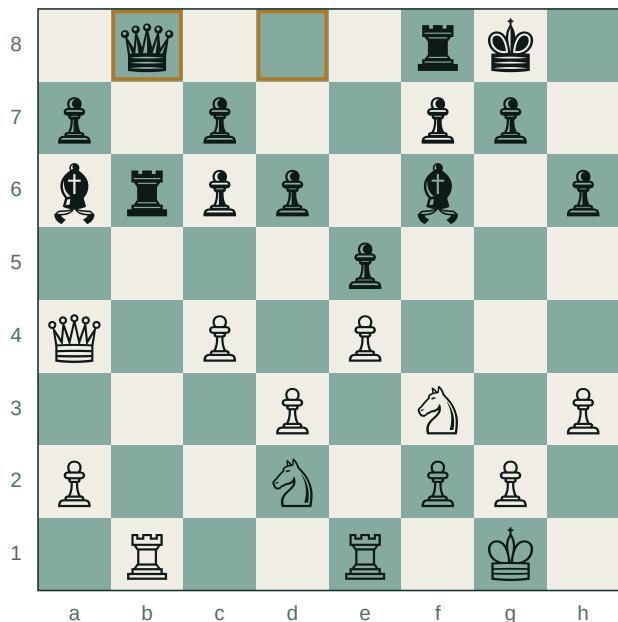


Capture the defender: White, move 15

Capture the defender

White to move



Previous move: 14...Qb8. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

15. Rxb6 axb6 16. Qxa6 Qa8 17. Qxa8

15.Rxb6 The rook captures the rook on b6. From b6 it attacks queen on b8 and bishop on a6. Recorded reply: **15...axb6**.

16.Qxa6 The queen captures the bishop on a6. Recorded reply: **16...Qa8**.

17.Qxa8 The queen captures the queen on a8.

At the end, nominal material is White 27 / Black 16 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, White's balance changes by +12. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does White's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer:** +12: the balance goes from -1 to +11. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

Do not assume a defender is unique. Another piece may take over its job, or the opponent may decline to recapture.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

Removing a key defender can transform a protected square into a winning entry. The defender's function explains why the first capture matters.

HOW TO LOOK

Identify the protected target, capture its essential defender, and calculate the follow-up after each plausible recapture.

The defending king is on g8. Look for a defender that can be displaced or overloaded.